

OneCup Compostable

A lid-free, one-piece, plant-free takeaway cup cafés can't stop photographing.

What It Is

A sustainable packaging brand selling a clever takeaway cup made from a single piece — no separate plastic lid. A small fold-down flap locks into place to create a spill-proof drinking spout, and the whole thing is plastic-free and compostable. It's a small design detail that saves cafés money, cuts waste, and is unusual enough that customers photograph and post it.

How It Makes Money

B2B wholesale: you sell cases of cups to independent cafés, coffee carts, juice bars, and food trucks who want lower packaging costs, an eco story, and free social buzz. Revenue from case orders, custom-branded print runs (cafés pay extra to put their logo on it), and recurring re-orders as a consumable.

Startup Costs

- First production run of one-piece compostable cups (Alibaba: "compostable paper cup no lid foldable" / "lidless takeaway cup"): MOQ 10,000–50,000
- Per-unit landed cost: \$0.06–\$0.14 per cup at 25,000–50,000 qty
- Custom die/tooling for the fold-lock design (if customizing): \$500–\$1,500 one-time
- Sea freight + duty on first order: \$600–\$1,500
- Samples + compostability certification docs: \$200–\$600
- Branding, B2B Shopify/line sheet, photography: \$500–\$1,200
- First-month outreach + sample budget for cafés: \$400–\$1,000
- **Total to launch: \$4,000–\$9,000**

The Numbers

- Landed cost per cup: ~\$0.10
- Wholesale price to cafés: \$0.18–\$0.28 per cup (still cheaper for them than cup + separate lid)
- Profit per cup: \$0.08–\$0.18
- Custom-print orders: +\$0.05–\$0.10 per cup margin
- A single busy café uses 1,000–3,000 cups/week
- Sign 25 cafés averaging 6,000 cups/month = 150,000 cups → **\$27,000–\$42,000 revenue, \$12,000–\$27,000 profit/month.**

How To Start

1. Source 2–3 Alibaba suppliers of one-piece foldable compostable cups; order samples and test the fold-lock spout for leaks.
2. Verify real compostability certification (BPI/EN13432) — cafés and eco buyers will ask.
3. Place a first run of 25,000–50,000 in 1–2 standard sizes (12oz, 16oz).
4. Build a B2B line sheet and a simple wholesale order page with case pricing.
5. Hand free sample cups to 30 independent cafés — let owners feel the "no lid needed" pitch.

6. Offer custom-printed runs so cafés brand their own cup (sticky, higher-margin accounts).
7. Set up auto-reorder reminders; cups are a consumable, so retention is the whole game.

Where To Get Customers

Independent cafés, coffee carts, juice/smoothie bars, and food trucks (in-person + DM); restaurant supply distributors; eco-focused B2B marketplaces and Faire; sustainability-minded chains and co-working spaces; Instagram/TikTok reels of the fold-lock spout to pull inbound café interest.

Pro Tips

- Lead with cost savings, not just eco — "one piece replaces cup + lid, so you buy less and store less" closes budget-conscious owners faster than guilt.
- Land custom-branded accounts; once a café prints its logo on your cup, switching suppliers is a hassle they'll avoid.
- Keep certification paperwork handy and on every listing — "compostable" claims without proof get rejected by serious buyers and risk greenwashing complaints.